

COAST OR CLIMB

The promotion wasn't what I thought it would be.

Chef de Cuisine. My own venue. Twenty-four years old and running a kitchen with fifteen staff, a hundred and fifty covers across double sittings, lunch and dinner seven days a week.

On paper, it was everything I'd been working toward.

In reality, it felt like a setup.

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I'd never set foot in the bistro before I accepted the role.

Never seen the kitchen. Never met the team. Gavin offered me the position, I said yes, and that was that.

How hard could it be?

I was about to find out.

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The first time I walked through the kitchen doors, I stopped dead.

Not in awe. Not in excitement.

In horror.

The place was filthy.

Benches streaked with old grease. Floors sticky underfoot. The kind of grime that doesn't happen in a week or a month — it builds over years of nobody giving a fuck.

The walk-in chiller had containers stacked without labels, half of them growing things that definitely weren't on any menu. The freezer was icing over around the door seals — thick, white frost creeping up the walls like the whole unit was slowly being swallowed.

Spoiled food. Unlabelled containers. Cross-contamination waiting to happen.

And the worst part?

This was a semi-open kitchen.

Guests could *see* this. They could see the chaos, the stains, the complete absence of anything resembling professional standards. They just didn't know what they were looking at.

But I did.

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The team was beaten down by years of nobody expecting anything from them.

Not incompetent — though some of them were. Just... broken.

Their uniforms told the story before anyone opened their mouth. Whites that weren't white anymore — yellowed, stained, the kind of discolouration that no amount of bleach would fix. Aprons that looked like they'd been used to mop the floor.

This was the brigade I'd inherited.

Fifteen people who'd been coasting so long they'd forgotten there was any other way to work.

I stood in the middle of that kitchen on my first day and thought:

What the fuck have I done.

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Then I looked at the menu.

And somehow, it got worse.

The napoli was canned tomatoes. Heated up. Pureed. That was it — no aromatics, no depth, no technique. Just tin-flavoured red sludge being passed off as a sauce. And this was the base for multiple dishes. *Multiple*.

The carbonara was a cream and garlic reduction with bacon that hadn't even been sautéed. Just raw, sad strips of pig fat floating in what looked like wallpaper paste.

The pastas were pre-cooked. Sitting in containers. Stuck together in congealed clumps, already overcooked before they'd even been reheated. The pesto was grey-green, stringy, bitter — the kind of thing you'd throw out if you found it in the back of your home fridge, let alone serve to paying guests.

Bought-in burger patties. Pre-made dressings. Everything that could be half-arsed had been half-arsed, and some things that shouldn't have been possible to half-arse had been half-arsed anyway.

This menu hadn't been changed in five years.

Five years.

And now my name was attached to it.

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I understood then what Gavin had done.

This wasn't a reward. This wasn't recognition for two years of holding the line and climbing faster than anyone expected.

This was a test.

He knew exactly what he was handing me. The worst venue in the resort. The bottom-of-the-barrel cooks. A kitchen that had been allowed to rot because nobody cared enough to fix it.

And he wanted to see what I'd do with it.

Either I'd prove that the standards I'd become known for weren't just talk — that I could take a disaster and turn it into something worth being proud of.

Or I'd fail. Publicly. Spectacularly. And everyone would know I'd been promoted beyond my abilities.

Make or break.

Gavin was betting on make.

I wasn't going to let him lose that bet.

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The first four months were war.

Not loud war. Not screaming matches and dramatic confrontations. Just slow, grinding, relentless pressure.

I didn't come in with speeches about transformation or new beginnings. I came in with requirements. Standards. Expectations that were now non-negotiable.

Uniforms would be clean. Whites would be white.

Stations would be set up properly. Mise en place labelled, dated, rotated.

Food would be tasted before it left the pass. Every time. No exceptions.

Walk-ins would be organised. Shelves wiped. Floors mopped. The freezer would be defrosted and maintained.

And the menu? The menu was going to change.

For the first time in five years.

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Here's the thing about standards.

You can't demand what you won't demonstrate.

I'd learned that at the vineyard. Watched Chef and Sam hold lines they never crossed themselves. Watched them stay late, arrive early, do the work nobody asked them to do because that's what the kitchen needed. The bollockings only meant something because they came from people who'd earned the right to give them.

If I was going to ask these people to change — really change, not just comply — I had to show them I wasn't above the work I was demanding.

Good for one, good for all.

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We didn't have the stewarding setup the main kitchen had.

No round-the-clock teams. No overnight deep-cleans. Just four boys — our own small crew, separate from the hotel's main operation.

Which meant clean-downs were on us.

Every night. Full breakdown. Benches scrubbed, floors mopped, equipment wiped, stations reset. Not a "quick tidy" — a proper clean-down, the kind where you could eat off the floor when you were done.

And once a fortnight, we went further.

The whole team rostered on. No exceptions. Floor to ceiling. Every surface, every shelf, every corner that usually got ignored. The extraction hoods came down. The cool room got stripped and scrubbed. The freezer got defrosted properly.

And I was right there with them.

Not in my whites — those had a different purpose now. Old t-shirt. Dirty jeans. Down on my hands and knees scrubbing the same grout as everyone else.

Those yellowed uniforms they'd been wearing? Now they had a place. Now they made sense. You don't wear your service whites to deep-clean a kitchen. You wear the ones that are already fucked.

The brigade noticed.

They noticed that the new CDC — the one who'd come in with all these demands and expectations and standards — wasn't standing at the pass watching them work. He was elbow-deep in the same filth they were, doing the same job, staying the same hours.

Morale doesn't come from speeches. It comes from proof.
And the proof was simple: every expectation I had for them was bolted directly to my own actions.

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The team didn't like it at first.

I didn't expect them to.

Some of them had been there longer than I'd been cooking. They'd built comfortable little routines — show up, do the minimum, go home, repeat. Nobody had asked anything more of them in years.

Now someone was.

And they resisted.

Not openly. Not with direct challenges or confrontations. That would've been easier, honestly. Instead, it was passive — the slow drag of people who'd rather wait you out than change.

Standards slipping when they thought I wasn't looking. Shortcuts taken. Requirements ignored.

He's new. He'll burn out. He'll realise this is how things work here and he'll adjust.

They were wrong.

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When someone didn't meet the standard, they got dressed down.

The same way I'd been dressed down. The same way Sam had done it — right there, in front of everyone, no privacy, no softening. The shame is part of the lesson. The audience is part of the point.

I remembered what it felt like to be on the receiving end. The heat in your face. The way your hands want to shake but you force them still. The knowledge that everyone heard, everyone saw, and now you have to either fix it or leave.

I'd stood where they were standing. I knew exactly how much it hurt.

And I did it anyway.

Because that's how standards get built. Not through memos and meetings and polite suggestions. Through public accountability. Through the understanding that fucking up doesn't disappear into a private conversation — it gets addressed in the room where it happened, in front of the people who had to work around it.

One by one, they found out I wasn't going to bend.

The guy who kept "forgetting" to label his containers? Reamed in front of the whole brigade until he understood that forgetting wasn't acceptable.

The cook who thought pre-cooked pasta was still good enough? Made to throw out the entire batch and start fresh, during service, with the whole kitchen watching.

The line cook who showed up in a stained apron because "nobody cares anyway"? Sent home to change. Docked the hour. And when he came back, I made sure he understood that I cared. That this kitchen cared now. That "nobody cares" wasn't a defence — it was the fucking problem.

I wasn't cruel about it. I wasn't theatrical.

I was just relentless.

The same relentlessness that had been applied to me.

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Five people left in those first four to six months.

Not all at once. One by one.

The pressure would build, the expectations would stay firm, and eventually they'd decide this wasn't worth it anymore. Hand in their notice. Walk out.

I didn't get replacements.

Gavin's decision, not mine. Whether it was budget or another layer of the test, I never found out. But suddenly I had ten staff doing the work of fifteen, same covers, and now we were pushing toward more technical food than the kitchen had ever attempted.

Ten people.

Less bodies, but every single one of them more capable than the five who'd left.

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Somewhere around the four-month mark, something shifted.

The rebellion stopped.

Not because I'd beaten it out of them — though maybe a bit of that. But because the ones who stayed started to see it.

The kitchen was cleaner. The mise was better. The food was actually *good* now — or at least, getting there. And the chaos that used to define every service? Replaced by something that felt almost like rhythm.

They'd watched me scrub floors alongside them. Watched me stay late when I could've gone home. Watched me hold myself to the same standards I was demanding from them — and they'd started to believe in themselves. In each other.

They started syncing with me.

Not fighting the current anymore. Moving with it.

I'd call a timing and hands would already be reaching for the right pan. I'd start plating and garnish would appear at my elbow without me asking. The calls and responses that used to feel forced started happening naturally — the kitchen was beginning to breathe like a single organism instead of ten separate people trapped in the same room.

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Sonny was the first to really click.

Indian lad, late twenties, visa-sponsored. He'd come in as a Demi — solid skills, good instincts, but coasting like everyone else. Once the standards went up, he didn't just meet them. He exceeded them. Started anticipating problems before they happened. Covered sections without being asked. Took ownership in a way I hadn't seen from anyone in that kitchen.

He'd be CDP by the time I left. My strongest chef.

Then there was Jen.

Korean girl, used to work in the main kitchen commissary. She asked for a transfer down to the bistro — actually *requested* it — because she'd heard things were changing and she wanted to be part of it. The passion that girl had for food was infectious. Every new ingredient, every technique, every small evolution in the menu — she approached it like a gift. Like she couldn't believe she was being allowed to learn.

And Praveen.

Late twenties. Commis. About four foot eight and an absolute beast on larder. The man could prep faster than people twice his size. In the beginning it was rough and inconsistent, but by the end his consistency was frightening. Same cut, same portion, same presentation, every single time. You could set your watch by his mise.

These were the people who stayed.

The ones who saw what the kitchen was becoming and decided they wanted to be part of building it.

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Nine months.

That's how long it took.

Nine months of double shifts and late nights. Lunch and dinner, seven days a week. The workload was familiar — I'd done this at the vineyard, done it harder in some ways — but the difference was that here, I was building something that was mine.

First new menu in five years.

Everything made in-house. Proper napoli — San Marzano tomatoes, fresh basil, garlic, a soffritto base that actually had depth. Carbonara done right — guanciale, egg yolk, pecorino, black pepper, no cream in fucking sight. Fresh pasta made daily. Pesto that was green, vibrant, balanced.

Handmade burger patties. Daily rotating specials. Desserts developed in-house — we still used the hotel pastry kitchen for some things, but my team was making their own specials now. Learning every day. Growing.

The bought-in garbage was gone.

The grey pesto — gone.

The congealed pasta clumps — gone.

And in their place? Food I could actually put my name to.

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Twelve months in, the brigade was strong.

Everyone looked sharp. Uniforms crisp and white. Aprons clean. The kitchen itself was unrecognisable from the disaster I'd walked into — organised, efficient, *proud*.

That last part mattered more than anything.

You could feel it radiating from the open pass now. The energy in the dining room had changed. That electric buzz that high-end venues have — the sense that something special is happening, that the people making your food actually give a shit — it was there. It was real.

And people noticed.

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The first sign was the executives.

Every lunch service, I'd look up from the pass and see them. Resort management. The people who ran this place.

In our dining room.

Eating our food.

Choosing this venue over every other option available to them.

They could've eaten anywhere.

They ate here.

That meant something.

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The second sign was quieter. But it hit harder.

Praveen asked if his parents could come in for dinner.

Not passing through — nobody passes through central Australia. His parents were coming from India. Specifically to see him.

To see where he worked.

What he'd helped build.

I said yes without hesitation.

Then I said we'd do something special.

We put together a menu just for them. A proper degustation — the kind of multi-course meal that requires the whole kitchen to move as one, every dish timed, every element perfect. The same format that had ignited something in me back at the vineyard, when I'd first felt what it meant to cook food that mattered.

Now we were doing it for Praveen's parents. During a normal service. Because he'd earned it.

I helped him cook everything. Let him call the dockets. Helped him plate. But it was *his* — his food, his moment, his parents watching from the dining room while their son ran the pass.

The hype that built in the team that night — the energy, the focus, the way everyone lifted without being asked — that's a feeling you don't forget.

It wasn't just Praveen's moment. It was proof of what we'd become.

A kitchen that would rally around one of its own. That understood some things matter more than covers and margins.

After service, his parents came to the pass.

Praveen wanted to introduce them. His mum stood back a little — quiet, reserved, the way I'd come to understand was typical of Indian families. His dad stepped forward.

"This is my chef."

That's how Praveen introduced me. Not "my boss." Not "the CDC." *My chef.*

His father shook my hand. Said thank you. Wasn't much more to it than that.

But Praveen was grinning like a Cheshire cat.

And so was everyone else. The whole brigade, watching from their sections, grinning for him.

That meant everything.

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I knew it was time to move on when the challenge stopped.

That's the thing nobody tells you about building something from nothing. There's a moment when the machine is running smoothly and the team is solid and the food is right — and suddenly it's not hard anymore.

The chaos that used to test you every single service?

The rebellion, the resistance, the constant pressure to hold the line?

All a distant memory.

What's left is maintenance. Keeping the engine running. Making sure nothing slips.

And for some people, that's enough.

For me, it was a sign.

The bistro didn't need me anymore. Sure, it needed someone who'd protect what we'd built — but it didn't need someone who'd burn themselves out chasing the next mountain.

I'd turned a sub-par venue with the bottom-of-the-barrel cooks into a kitchen that made everything in-house. Food cooked accurately, to order. The level of precision I craved, restored.

The team that remained weren't just competent — they were extensions of my own body. We moved in unison. Like puppets on strings, but in the way that means trust, not control.

I'd done what Gavin bet I would do.

Now it was time to find the next thing that would try to break me.